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Opening the Discussion of Literature Censorship to College-aged Students

Introduction:

Within the realm of literary censorship, two divisive stances have been and continue to be explored and exploited: for the censorship of sensitive topics and against censorship. For those arguing the need for censorship of sensitive literature, commonly held concerns include that exposing younger or less mature readers to sensitive topics takes away the innocence of youth. If, however, these younger readers must be exposed to sensitive topics, that exposition should be done by the parental figures and not an educational system. On the inverse of this stance, those who are arguing against censorship state the need for younger readers to gain the emotional depth and maturity given by studying and addressing sensitive topics. The United States First Amendment is also commonly cited here as an argument for the right to free speech, even if the topics challenge personal beliefs.

For the purpose of this paper, the following definitions will be used and addressed. Sensitive literature is defined as literature containing themes or topics that are considered triggering to readers. Such themes or topics include abortion, domestic violence, sexual assault, and physical and mental health concerns. This consensus on which topics are considered sensitive comes from the independent survey discussed below. Censorship, as defined in the

Encyclopedia Britannica, is the limiting or omitting of certain pieces of literature in order to preserve either the innocence of the readers or to align with a specific agenda (Anastaplo 1).

While research traditionally focuses on how censorship of sensitive topics affects younger audiences, it fails to address how that same censorship of literature continues to college-aged students. In order to address this concern, this paper will include a locally conducted survey of college students from Brigham Young University - Idaho and Arizona State University and their experiences with censorship throughout their college experiences. This survey will also show that by limiting the discussion of sensitive literature to only teachers and grade school learners that it is isolating the next generation of academics. This need for equal voices in censorship discussions will be shown through first examining the differing arguments for and against censorship, how those arguments are affecting college students, and how college students can be integrated fully into the discussion of literary censorship. While arguments for and against literary censorship continue to focus narrowly on younger audiences, college students deserve an equal voice in that discussion, not just as passive learners, but as active participants who deserve a voice in shaping how sensitive literature is taught and engaged with.

Argument for Censorship:

In order to best address how to approach censorship of sensitive topics and how to involve college students as a central part of the conversation, the following two positions must be broached: the argument for and the argument against censorship. Individuals who argue for additional censorship within literature identify the following areas of concern for why certain pieces of literature need to be censored. In the “National Report of Teachers' Experiences With School Justifications for Book Censorship”, within a survey of 4,096 public educators, they

consistently “found that 57% included sex/sex-related topics or content, 44% included characters or people of color, and 39% included LGBTQ+ characters or people [were censored]. Further, the texts address grief and death (59%), substance use/abuse (40%), mental health disorders (38%), and empowerment and self-esteem (37%). Aucoin's ([3]) retrospective study of the content of ALA's top 100 censored texts found that the most common controversial topics included violence, sexually explicit content, and offensive language” (Ginsberg 3). The researchers go on to note that when a geographic area is more financially secure, there was a significant increase in the literary censorship within the schools (Ginsberg 5). Consistently, the discussion surrounding additional censorship shows that sensitive topics such as sexual assault, violence, and minority groups continue to be sources of concerns for guardians and educators.

The reasoning behind this censorship of literature in the school systems was addressed in the study with the following. “Censors' justifications presumed that teachers could not support students' critical thinking of these topics, and for others, censors seemed to worry more about teachers' values pervading the classroom environment” (Ginsberg 11). While areas with a lower socioeconomic status tend to trust the educators more to find and remove the items of sensitive literature from their student bodies, parents and guardians from higher socioeconomic areas often feel it is more of their responsibility, and not the responsibility of the teachers, to control what their children have access to reading. Thus, censorship of sensitive literature derives both from private and public spheres for younger audiences.

Jennifer Moore and Alissa Tudor, in their article “To Add or Not to Add: An Examination of Self-Censoring Behaviors among School Librarians”, further examine the driving force behind the censorship of sensitive topics in literature. Moore and Tudor identify that there is a key difference between their roles as educators and the role of the parent or guardian explaining that

as educators censor, they are censoring as an internal entity or as the one who has the most experience with the test. However, when parents censor, they are censoring as the external entity and are prioritizing the impact of the individual reader (Moore 6). The two groups out of necessity will often be at an impasse as the ways that parents censor depends on their social, economic, racial, and religious background (Moore 19). This separation often causes double the amount of censorship on younger learners as both guardians and educators strive to protect the young in their spheres of influence (Shanks 4).

Argument Against Censorship:

Opposing the argument for censorship stands organizations that both expose and catalogue which books are being censored and the reasonings behind the censorship of these books. In order to “protect the freedom to read”, the American Library Association puts out continuing lists and statistics about the amount of books being censored every year stating, “When a library book is censored based upon the identity of its author or one of its characters, or because someone disapproves of the views expressed within it, a voice is silenced antidemocratically and a community is deprived of the opportunity to learn from a differing perspective” (American Library Association 1). PEN America, an organization that documents the censorship of books and is primarily composed of authors and communicators, states that it stands “at the intersection of literature and human rights to protect free expression in the United States and worldwide. We champion the freedom to write, recognizing the power of the word to transform the world” (PEN America 1). These organizations are advocating for the right to free speech and the need to uphold those values, regardless of how sensitive the information may be to readers.

At the forefront of the arguments against censorship is the concern that by omitting sensitive topics from literature that it will make future generations of learners less emotionally capable and competent. Brianna Johns addresses this concern head on in her article “Book Banning in US Schools and Prisons as Modern-day Slave Codes”. Johns states, “Books hold so much power that enslavers suppressed literacy to oppress the enslaved in the eighteenth century. Today, harmful legislation emerges in schools and libraries nationwide, and prisons even dictate the criteria for permitted reading materials. . . In the tapestry of history, suppressing literature through book bans evokes a haunting parallel with the deliberate control of information during the era of American slavery” (Johns 39). Just as the ban on literacy for American slaves decreased their ability to communicate and relate on an emotional level to the people around them, Johns argues that censoring sensitive topics will do the same for our younger generations of learners (Johns 37). This argument is continued by Rachel Li in “We Can't Be Sheltered”: Why Banned Books Matter” when she states, “Censorship is how we limit expression, how systems in power force the oppressed to think in certain ways. It is how the government can control its citizens and their way of thinking. It is how those in power limit those without a voice. It is a misremembering of people, an intentional ignorance of often-untold narratives. It is deceiving the population into thinking that racial or other marginalized groups can only behave in a certain way. It is failing people and failing education. It is failing students and teachers, readers and writers, people who seek knowledge and liberation. It is having politics dictate something that it should never have intervened with in the first place” (Li 1). Both Johns and Li clearly state that censorship is not the cure all that opposers think it will be, but it will be a way to stifle individual growth and thoughts. Just as slavery oppressed individuals for centuries, so

will literary censorship oppress younger learners if certain topics are not addressed privately or publicly while the learners are young.

Rebuttal of Both Stances:

However, while these studies appropriately address the main concerns for why certain books were censored and why individuals continue to be concerned over the amount of literature being censored, the studies continue to fall short at how this censorship at a young age impacts the grown students who are currently in college. Though the discussion of censorship has been shown to be heavily debated between educators and guardians, as children grow into adults, they are still being left out of these discussions. Within the survey directed to upperclassmen across universities, an anonymous student highlighted this concern when they said, “It's hard to understand something you have no knowledge of”. While the educational and parental systems battle for what topics should be addressed and what should be censored, young adults are currently still lost in a censorship discussion they haven't been given an opportunity to embrace. While the censoring of children gives the parents and educators a greater chance to monitor what children are exposed to, it also leaves those children at a disadvantage as they grow into higher education.

While these arguments against censoring literature show the concerns of individuals for having individual voices and concerns shown to a younger audiences, within the Johns and Li articles, and address the impact on the older generations, like the websites shown above, none of these articles or websites approach the college-aged students to see how they might approach censorship. While the arguments against censorship are aimed at helping students to become

more well-rounded and emotionally sensitive adults, the research is neglecting to involve the students and next generations of adults in the process.

In a survey sent specifically to English majors and minors and when asked about the impact of censoring as children as opposed to adults, the responses were greatly varied and not as consistent as the previous arguments would like to suppose. One individual remarked when asked if their opinions on censoring had changed as they got older, “As we are now adults, there is not really a reason to be censored from what happens in the world”. However, other individuals in the same survey group remarked that “I believe that censorship is a personal thing that should be addressed by age and respected if a person does have certain sensitivities to certain topics”. A final individual remarked, “ I believe that more important than censoring something should be ensuring that it is discussed appropriately outside of the text to gain an understanding of it”. Although this survey was sent to a distinct minority within college groups, as shown in the responses above, the answers were not consistent and unified.

Thus, this concern that censorship will stifle individual thought is directly refuted by the response of the students. As this survey was conducted with a group of similar religious and educational values who had all experienced a degree of censorship, it stands to reason that the censorship of these individuals at a young age would have encouraged them to feel and respond the same way. However, this lack of similar responses shows that censorship does not entirely impact a student’s response as an adult.

Conclusion:

Ultimately, while neither the argument for censorship or against censorship can have clear battle lines on the correct decision to make, the need for college-aged students to be more

involved in the discussion is conclusive. When reviewing the responses of the surveys sent to the upperclassmen, English majors and minors, and varied majors at Arizona State University and Brigham Young University - Idaho, the results are the same. When asked if they would like to be involved more in the decisions made in their classes about what topics to censor, almost half of the students in all surveys answered definitely that they would like to be part of the discussion. Of all the questions posed in the surveys, the question of if they wanted to be more involved in the discussions around censorship was the most decisive. This is shown in the table below.

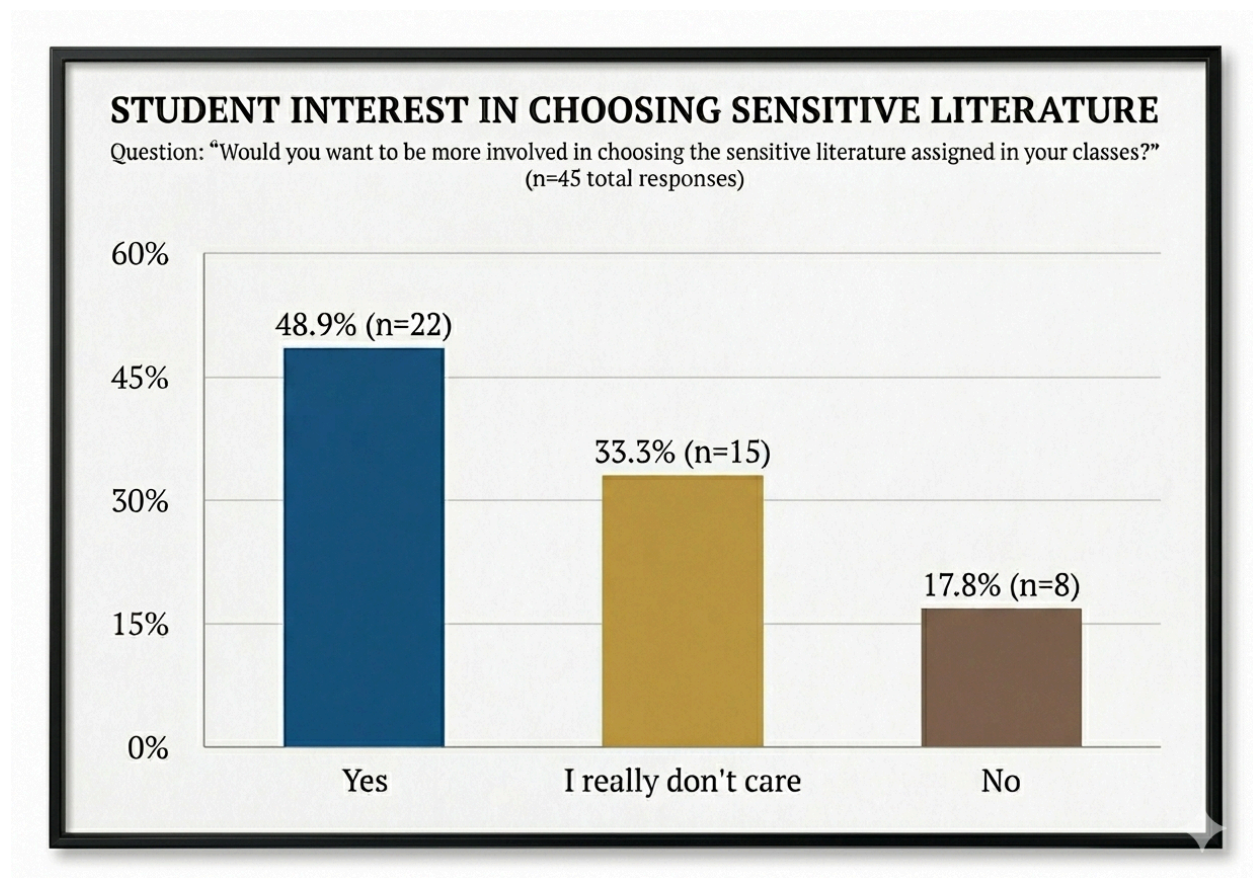


Table 1 showing the different responses in students choosing censorship involvement

Consistently, the students argued that while they might not be as experienced in academia and life as the educators they work with, they still feel that their experiences should help to dictate what should be read in an educational setting. One student remarked, “I’ve seen the way too much censorship in classes affects the meaning behind literature.” Another student said, “I realize now that there are some subjects that should not be shown to younger ages.” Finally, a student said, “I used to be much more on the “depends on the age groups” side, but after meeting or hearing about kids exposed to these serious topics when they were young and how compassionate and understanding they are, I now believe everyone should be exposed to them in school. We don’t have to show graphic pictures to get the point across. Children can understand, grasp, and handle a lot more than we give them credit for. As the last 3 years have unfolded, especially the last 2, it has become very clear to me that the sources of wickedness in our communities often come from those not exposed to these topics when they were younger. ”

While the opinions for or against censorship are varied within college students, consistently the students want to and are willing to be more involved with the discussions about censorship in their lives and the lives of other students.

If research only focuses on the debate for or against censorship, it neglects to see what opportunities could arise from choosing to open up that discussion to college students. While the argument for censorship, shown through the Ginsberg and Moore articles, helps protect younger learners from sensitive topics and materials, that same censorship is keeping college-aged students from being able to relate to their peers. Likewise, though the ALA and PEN websites help to show current educators which books and topics are being censored, they are not shown as viable resources for college students to use to form their own opinions and are often not shown

in an educational setting for the students to choose if they want to use those resources for themselves.

Ultimately, opening up the censorship discussion will provide the next generation of leaders and thinkers with the chance to take hold of their own desire to learn and grow. Instead of becoming confused when books are removed from student curriculums or libraries, college students should have the opportunity to be part of the discussion and also be part of the consequences of those decisions. This choice to be involved in the conversations around sensitive literature will give those same college students the foundation on which to continue to morally choose throughout the rest of their lives and to be the independent thinkers of tomorrow.

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